Policy Name: **Internal Communications Policy**

Policy Number: VII. Business Practices 03

Application: Full-time and part-time staff, temporary employees and Library contractors
Date Issued: May 26, 2020
Date Revised: October 23, 2020; October 7, 2024
Effective Date: October 7, 2024

Policy Statement:
The Organization uses technology to allow staff to communicate and collaborate internally and with external partners. Not all tools are appropriate for all communications. This policy outlines the most common types of internal communications, as well as usage guidelines and expectations for each. All staff are responsible for learning how to use the tools relevant to their work and staying engaged during normal and emergency operations.

All internal communications tools using Internet-related technologies are affected by this policy. This includes the posting of policies and procedures, online databases, forms, schedules, discussion forums, chat, email, email distribution lists and video conferencing. Additionally, all internal communications are subject to Social Media and Harassment Policies. Staff should not use open internal communications tools to discuss personnel or employment issues, or to share patrons' personal identifying information (unless there is a business reason). All internal communications are the property of the company and staff should not assume privacy.

All internal communications should:

1. Have a clear purpose
2. Be tailored to a specific audience
3. Be timely
4. Be concise
5. Be consistent with other messaging and policies

Email

Email is a baseline communication tool that all staff are expected to use. This means reading and responding to your colleagues', supervisors', and potential partner organizations' emails in a timely and professional manner as determined by your role and supervisor. Staff are expected to use emails for formal communications and external correspondence.

Staff may be a part of one or more email distribution lists and workgroups. These lists, organized by department and committee, are used to easily communicate information to a large group. Not all staff may email all distribution lists; permissions will be set by administration based on department and role. Email distribution lists must be used to communicate professional, work-specific information; they should not be used to facilitate a group chat or casual discussion. Emails sent to all staff through either All Users or a combination of multiple distribution lists must first be approved by the sender's supervisor. Use of distribution lists in a manner that causes employee inboxes to quickly become overloaded, causes disruption, or to share content that violates this, or any other policy, may result in permissions restrictions and/or disciplinary action up to and including termination. It is best practice to use the BCC address field when

sending to a distribution list. Employees should not "reply all" to distribution list emails; they should instead reply directly to the sender.

In an emergency, only authorized personnel should communicate via email distribution lists.

Employee email signatures should conform to the latest standards set by Marketing & Communications, available on the Intranet.

Intranet

The Intranet is company's official employee communications platform—a top-down medium used to communicate Library policies, benefits information and staff news, as well as allow staff to manage and access their employee profiles and records (such as timesheets, W-2s, etc.), and submit service requests and reports (maintenance, marketing materials, public safety reports, etc.). The Intranet is available to all staff.

Intranet policy and content is managed by the Communications and HR teams. Content drafted by staff will be reviewed and approved (and may also be edited) in order to ensure content suitability, accuracy, tone and style. Content owners are responsible for keeping their information up to date; failure to do so may result in the removal of content from the Intranet.

Chat

Internal chat tools, such as Slack and Microsoft Teams, are available for staff to make internal communications, especially across departments and teams, more efficient. Posting content on some channels may be restricted to senior staff. Chat tools may also be used to connect employees with shared interests. While more casual in nature, workplace chat tools are

subject to all BPL employee policies. Language used must be appropriate for the workplace and may not be offensive, discriminating, threatening or perceived as bullying.

While chat tools may be used to reinforce information or share reminders, they should not be used as a formal method of communication. Staff should always submit service requests through the appropriate channel, available via the Intranet, or by email.

Avatars and Profiles

Staff profiles used for internal communications should accurately reflect department, title and contact information. Informal avatars may be used in communications channels such as chat; however, they must be appropriate for the workplace. Avatars for formal communications, such as the Intranet staff directory, Workday and Office 365, must be a clear and recognizable photo of the user if activated.

Wiki / Crowdsourced Employee Information

Crowdsourced content platforms, such as the Wiki, are a -specific information resource created and curated by colleagues. Crowdsourced platforms are best used to share knowledge or learn best practices about public programs, services, outreach, collection management and more.

Employee-generated information on policies, procedures and benefits is not appropriate for a crowdsourced platform; it may cause confusion and in an extreme case, damage to the organization, if incorrect or outdated information is shared. Content referencing official policies and procedures should be linked to the appropriate Intranet page in order to ensure accuracy. Staff adding content to crowdsourced platforms are responsible for keeping the information relevant and current—by adding or editing content to

crowdsourced platforms, employees are agreeing to maintain said content. Employees who do not keep their content up to date may lose access to crowdsourced tools. Outdated content may be deleted.

Videoconferencing

Staff participating in videoconferencing are expected to engage in behavior that is appropriate for the workplace. Staff should use sound judgment regarding aspects of videoconferencing such as attire and background. Virtual backgrounds may be used as long as they are in no way offensive, discriminating or threatening and must be appropriate for the workplace.

Phone

All employees are expected to set up basic voicemail for their unique extension, and check and return messages on a regular basis. Employees should treat Teams calls as they would a traditional call and be responsive accordingly. Employees with work-issued mobile phones, as well as those who access work communications on their personal devices, are also expected to follow these guidelines as well as respond to work-related text messages. Work text messaging is subject to all communications regulations.

Failure to adhere to these guidelines may result in disciplinary action up to and including termination.

This policy will be reviewed annually and updated as necessary.

Issuing Agency: Marketing & Communications

Revision Date: October 7, 2024

Related Policies:
Social Media (II Staff #26)
Technology Use (HR#12)

Preceded by: Intranet Policy

Internal Communications Community Norms
rev August 16, 2024

Brooklyn Public Library's Internal Communications Policy addresses intra-staff communications, tools and protocols. This document provides more detailed guidelines for specific communications tools and types.

Slack

Slack is an internal communications tool used by BPL to support collaboration, information sharing and camaraderie. Slack is *not* a formal method of communication and should not be used for formal service requests. While some departments may opt to respond to such requests on Slack, staff should always default to using the appropriate reporting form or application (for example, Resolver, MACConnect, Eptura, etc.).

The success of Slack depends on its users abiding by community norms and using channels effectively and efficiently. In the interest of keeping Slack a productive virtual space, we ask that you adhere to the following guidelines.

All messages posted on Slack are subject to BPL employee policies. Please use good judgment when posting both public and private messages. Staff should not use Slack to discuss personnel matters or employment issues.

The **#all-users** channel is meant for systemwide news and updates pertaining to BPL that affect all staff. Appropriate content includes reminders about large-scale meetings, HR information, announcements about systemwide programs, policy updates and branch opening/closing information. Examples of content that should *not* be posted here include political information, news articles, individual branch programs, health information or questions to a specific department. While all staff may post in #all-users, only Slack admins may use the @channel or @here notification feature. Since #all-users is the only channel that employees must be a part of, limited full-channel notifications ensure all staff receive the most important announcements. Non-admins are also restricted from using @channel or @here in the #watercooler channel.

For posts not appropriate for #all-users, please consider using these topical public channels:

- **#hype-this** - promote your branch programs here so that others can help spread the word and support your work
- **#watercooler** - popular culture, news articles (about both librarianship and other items of interest), general chat

Off-topic posts and content not appropriate for the workplace in public channels may be removed by Slack administrators. Thank you for helping us keep Slack effective and efficient.

Virtual Meetings

Virtual meetings, using technology such as Microsoft Teams and Zoom, are a part of standard business operations at BPL. In order to keep virtual gatherings of all sizes efficient and workplace-appropriate, BPL has established the following guidelines for virtual meetings.

Conduct: Attendees at virtual meetings should conduct themselves as though they are at an in-person meeting or presentation. Participants are expected to exhibit workplace-appropriate behavior and give their attention to the presenter or speaker. Bullying or heckling on video or in chat, along with sharing off-topic communication during a meeting, is prohibited.

Identification: All employees must identify themselves in virtual meetings by using their real name and job title, if included. Anonymous attendees and attendees using pseudonyms may be removed by the meeting leader or moderator.

Moderation: Any virtual meeting with more than 20 people should designate a moderator. The moderator should be available throughout the meeting and collect attendee questions for meeting leaders to address, either during the meeting or shortly thereafter.

Chat: Any virtual meeting with more than 100 attendees will not feature live chat for the meeting's duration. Ongoing live chat among a large number of people is distracting to both the presenter and the other attendees. Additionally, live chat makes it difficult for moderators and meeting leaders to identify and answer questions. Meeting leaders can choose to open live chat for segments of the meeting, and any live chat sessions will be indicated on the meeting agenda. Attendee questions and comments should be shared directly with the meeting moderator when live chat is off.

Recording: If a meeting is being recorded, the purpose of the recording should be shared. All staff must be informed before recording begins. Employees may not make personal recordings of internal meetings or share recordings or screenshots of meetings outside of the organization.